

L-46: Indian Society

Future of Caste System | Impact of Buddhism, Jainism, Islam & Christianity
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L-46: COMPLETE TOPIC MAP

Part A: Future of Caste System

Part B: Impact of Buddhism

Part C: Impact of Jainism

Part D: Impact of Islam

Part E: Impact of Christianity

PART A: FUTURE OF CASTE SYSTEM IN INDIA (Unit 3.2)

Introduction & Context

- Caste = one of the **oldest forms of social stratification**; shaped India's social, economic & political life for millennia
- Reformers like **Gandhi** and **Ambedkar** envisioned reform or abolition — yet caste persists in overt and subtle ways
- Future of caste = tension between **persistence** and **transformation**

M. N. Srinivas

Caste adapts through **Sanskritisation** and **Westernisation** rather than disappearing — it transforms its character while retaining its hold on social organisation

1. Present Reality of Caste

- Caste shows **little sign of weakening** in India
- Castes seek **upward mobility** by forming associations — function as pressure groups for jobs, education, and political influence
- Examples: **All India Brahmin Association**, **All India Yadav Association**
- Caste identity = key basis for **social organisation** and **political mobilisation**

Counter-View

- In urban contexts and high-skill sectors like IT, hiring often values **merit over caste**
- Banerjee** (study): limited caste bias in software jobs when qualifications are equal
- DICCI** (Dalit Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry) = new forms of Dalit assertion through **entrepreneurship**

2. Reformist vs Abolitionist Approaches

Two major ideological strands on what to do with caste:

Approach	Thinker	Core Argument
Reformist	Gandhi	Argued for a purified varna system where duties were based on qualities, not birth
Abolitionist	Ambedkar + G.S. Ghurye	Saw caste as inherently oppressive ; demanded its complete destruction

B. R. Ambedkar — *Annihilation of Caste*

"Political democracy cannot last unless social democracy is achieved." —
Without dismantling caste, democracy remains superficial

Counter-View / Alternative Approaches

- Lingayat movement** — rejected caste hierarchy outright (12th century Karnataka)
- Chandra Bhan Prasad** — "Dalit Capitalism": entrepreneurship as a tool for social dignity; caste hierarchies can be challenged through **economic means** rather than only political mobilisation

3. Remedies Suggested

 **Narmadeshwar Prasad (1957)** — conducted a survey of **1,225 respondents** to identify most effective remedies for weakening caste:

Remedy	% Respondents	Rationale
Expanding education & economic opportunities	39.1%	Reduces dependence on traditional caste-based occupations
Promoting inter-caste marriages	35.3%	Directly challenges endogamy; fosters social integration
Ensuring equality of treatment in everyday life	13.4%	Gradually erodes caste prejudice in social interactions
Removing untouchability in practice	12.2%	Through both legal enforcement and social reform

Supporting Evidence & Data

- Hnatkovska & Lahiri (2012)**: documented **convergence in education and wages** for SCs/STs from 1980s to 2010s — education IS reducing gaps
- Inter-caste marriages: only **5% nationally** (IHDS-2, 2011-12) but slowly rising in urban areas
- NFHS-5 data**: inter-caste marriages linked to **better child nutrition** — positive externalities
- Pew Survey 2021**: attitudes remain rigid overall, yet younger and urban Indians show significantly more openness to inter-caste interaction

4. Obstacles & Political Reinforcement

- **Mandal Verdict (1992)** — Supreme Court upheld caste as the basis for reservations → affirmed salience of caste in public policy
- Politics continues to **reinforce caste identity** — electoral mobilisation remains deeply caste-based (vote banks, caste arithmetic)

Pauline Kolenda (1997)
A system shaping Indian society for over 1,000 years cannot vanish within decades — structural inertia is immense

Counter-View: Signs of Change

- **EWS Quota (2019)**: introduced **economic criteria** for reservation — loosening caste as the sole axis of affirmative action
- **Bihar Caste Survey (2023)**: provides nuanced socio-economic data, helping rethink welfare policies beyond traditional caste categories
- **Christophe Jaffrelot**: caste politics has also **empowered marginalised groups**, enabling new forms of bargaining power (democratic assertion from below)

5. Persistence of Caste Practices

A. Endogamy (Marriage within caste)

Only 5%
of marriages are inter-caste nationally (IHDS-2, 2011-12). Caste remains the **primary criterion** in matrimonial alliances despite legal freedom.

B. Untouchability

27%
of India still practises untouchability — more than 1 in 4 people (NCAER & University of Maryland Survey)

Breakdown by Caste & Religion:

By Caste	%	By Religion	%
Brahmin	52%	Hindu	35%
Forward castes	24%	Jain	30%
OBC	15%	Sikh	23%
SC	22%	Muslim	18%
ST	13%	Christian	5%
Others	27%	Buddhist	1%

C. Hereditary Occupations

Certain jobs remain **heavily caste-linked** — little generational change:

State	Occupation Data
Uttar Pradesh	Out of 46,000 leather workers → 41,000 are from Chamars, Dhusia & Jatava castes SC sweepers (age 35-59): 63.4% Balmikis SC sweepers (age 15-34): 62% Balmikis (little generational change!) Leather work (35-59 age group): 88.2% Chamars, Dhusias & Jatavas
Rajasthan	Out of 76,000 sweepers → almost 52,000 are Bhangi, Mehtar & Chura
Madhya Pradesh	Similar caste-occupation pattern persists

Counter-View: Forces of Change

- Endogamy weakening slightly among **educated and urban youth** — inter-caste unions increasing through modern matrimonial platforms
- **Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers Act (2013)** — directly challenges untouchability in practice
- **NAMASTE Scheme (2022)**: mechanises sanitation work — technology replacing caste-based labour
- Technological modernisation in all occupations further erodes caste-based job divisions

Conclusion: Future of Caste

KEY CONCLUSION

- Caste will remain a **significant social reality** in India's foreseeable future
- Persistence ensured by: **endogamy + caste-based politics + entrenched social attitudes**
- Caste is undergoing **transformation**: less about **ritual hierarchy** → more about **identity, politics, and access to resources**
- Future = **persistence in new forms**, NOT disappearance
- Challenge: ensure caste identities do NOT translate into caste inequalities

Andre Beteille
*The tension between **caste and class** will define India's social structure — while the state and civil society must continue working towards reducing inequities sustained by caste*

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Identity Politics:** Caste has shifted from a ritual hierarchy to a tool of political identity — understanding this transformation is central to studying contemporary Indian stratification
- **Intersectionality:** Caste intersects with class, gender & religion — Dalit women face triple marginalisation (caste + class + gender); anthropologists study these overlapping inequalities
- **Digital Caste:** Matrimonial apps, LinkedIn caste networks, and social media casteism show caste adapting to digital spaces (new research frontier)
- **Diaspora Dimension:** California's SB 403 (2023) — first US state to ban caste discrimination; caste travels beyond India into global diaspora communities
- **Policy Relevance:** Bihar Survey 2023, EWS quota, sub-categorisation of OBCs — all require anthropological understanding of how caste operates differently in different regions
- **Applied Anthropology:** NAMASTE scheme, manual scavenger elimination programmes — anthropological insights into occupational caste help design effective interventions

Positive Impacts

1. Social Life — Egalitarianism

- Buddhism **rejected the varna system**
- **Anyone could join the Sangha** (monastic community), irrespective of caste or gender
- This was revolutionary in a society where birth determined everything

 **R. S. Sharma**

*This shift encouraged recognition of **achieved status** over birth-based status, especially in early urban centres — a fundamental challenge to the Brahmanical order*

2. Status of Women

- Women were allowed to become **nuns** (bhikkhunis) and pursue education and spiritual life
- This was unprecedented in a society where women had virtually no religious agency

 **Uma Chakravarti**

*Works like the Therigatha show how early Buddhist nuns expressed **intellectual and spiritual autonomy** — a significant step in gender empowerment that had no parallel in contemporary Brahmanical society*

3. Ethics & Morality

- Buddhism offered a **code of conduct** emphasising: truth, non-violence, compassion, restraint from theft or alcohol
- This was a moral framework based on **reason**, not priestly authority

 **S. Radhakrishnan**

*These principles acted as **civic ethics** — a new form of social control **beyond ritual sanction**. They governed behaviour through conscience rather than fear of divine punishment*

4. Intellectual Freedom

- **Logic replaced superstition**; Buddhism encouraged people to think for themselves
- Teachings written in **Pali** (not Sanskrit) — this enabled ordinary people to access knowledge, question rituals and dogma without needing priestly intermediaries

 **Richard Gombrich**

*The Pali canon emphasised **reasoned inquiry**, making debate and questioning the **default mode** of religious learning — a radical democratisation of knowledge*

5. Literature

Text	Significance
Pali Canon (Tipitaka)	Preserved the earliest teachings of Buddha; 3 baskets (Vinaya, Sutta, Abhidhamma)
Jataka Tales	Narrated Buddha's earlier births with moral lessons; popular folk literature
Therigatha	Reflected women's voices — poems by female nuns expressing spiritual freedom
Apabhramsa writings	Buddhism & Jainism's writings in local languages enriched Indian linguistic traditions

PART B: IMPACT OF BUDDHISM ON INDIAN SOCIETY (Unit 3.4)

BUDDHISM — 9 SPHERES OF IMPACT

1. Social Equality
2. Women's Status
3. Ethics & Morality
4. Intellectual Freedom
5. Literature
6. Education
7. Art & Architecture
8. Economic Life
9. Political Life

Context at the Time of Buddha

- Indian society was **static, hierarchical**, and dominated by rituals and sacrifices
- **Ascribed status** given primacy over achieved status
- Conditions particularly harsh for **women, shudras, and some vaishyas**
- Buddhism emerged in response — **rejected**: caste divisions, ritual sacrifices, priestly monopoly
- **Preached**: equality, ethics, and intellectual freedom

The Essence of Buddhism: Noble Eightfold Path

#	Path	#	Path
1	Right Understanding	5	Right Livelihood
2	Right Thought	6	Right Effort
3	Right Speech	7	Right Mindfulness
4	Right Action	8	Right Concentration

6. Education

- Most ancient Indian universities are products of Buddhism:
Nalanda, Vikramshila, Taxila, Valabhi
- These were among the world's first residential universities — attracted students from across Asia

R. C. Majumdar

At Taxila, Buddhist and non-Buddhist subjects like **law, medicine, and grammar** coexisted — showing the **broad, secular scope of education** that went far beyond religious instruction

7. Art & Architecture

 A. L. Basham

Highlights the **Gandhara and Mathura schools of art**, which flourished due to Buddhist patronage — reflecting the blending of local Indian and foreign (Hellenistic) artistic influences

Art Form	Key Examples
Pillars	Ashoka Pillars in Bihar and UP — earliest monumental Indian art
Stupas	Sanchi, Sarnath, Nalanda — architectural marvels; symbols of Buddhist cosmology
Figurines	Kanheri, Karle, Nasik — rock-cut cave art
Sculptures	Barabar, Ajanta — regarded as masterpieces of Buddhist religious art
Paintings	Ajanta, Ellora — got universal attention; finest examples of Indian mural art
Carvings	On railings and gates of stupas — depicted events from Buddha's life

8. Economic Life

- Buddhism **opposed animal sacrifice**, encouraged agriculture, and sanctified the cow
- Monasteries became **nodes of economic life** — not just spiritual centres

 Upinder Singh

Monasteries were often located along **trade routes** — acting as **hubs of commerce and exchange**, facilitating long-distance trade networks

 Hermann Kulke

Monasteries provided **social services** — distributing food and medical care, enhancing welfare functions in the community

9. Political Life

Welfare dimension:

- Vaishyas and Shudras (who were looked down upon in Hinduism) converted in large numbers
- Those who were not of "any concern" to rulers in the past — now their welfare was taken up

Romila Thapar

Ashoka's dhamma was not a creed but a model of **ethical kingship**, emphasising welfare and moral governance — governance as a moral duty, not just power exercise

Non-violence:

- This message was reverberating post-**Kalinga War** — carved in pillars and spread through **dharma mahamatras** (officers for propagation of dhamma)

Negative Impacts of Buddhism

1. Decline of Vedic Ritual Economy
R. S. Sharma: Buddhism's rejection of elaborate Vedic sacrifices **reduced the importance of priests** in the ritual economy — weakened the traditional Brahmanical order, created tensions with orthodox groups who depended on the ritual economy

2. Monastic Withdrawal from Society
Romila Thapar: Growth of Buddhist monasteries sometimes led to **economic withdrawal from productive activities** — monks depended on lay donations, which could strain agrarian communities and limit wider participation in economic life

3. Decline in Military Strength
Emphasis on non-aggression, non-violence, ascetic life & spiritualism **weakened the militancy of Indians** and caused decline in military strength → India fell easy prey to foreign invaders who came in quick succession → centuries of political subjugation

Spread of Buddhism

Outside India (via Ashoka)

- Buddhism spread through **dharma mahamatras** (special officers)
- According to **Mahavamsa**: In the 17th year of Ashoka's reign, at end of 3rd Buddhist Council, he sent missionaries to **9 parts of the world**
- Sent daughter **Sanghamitra** and son **Mahindra** to spread Buddhism in **Sri Lanka**

Decline within India

- Buddhism became primarily a **monastic movement** — lost touch with lay supporters
- Many monasteries became **very wealthy** — employed indentured slaves and paid labourers to tend lands
- After **Muslim invaders sacked monasteries** (12th–13th centuries) → no revival until 20th century

20th Century Revival

Year	Institution/Event
1891	Maha Bodhi Society — modernist Buddhist organisation
1892	Bengal Buddhist Association
1898	Young Men's Buddhist Association
1950s	B. R. Ambedkar (1891-1956) — influenced by Pali sources and Indian Buddhists like Dharmanand Kosambi and Lakshmi Narasu — promoted conversion to Buddhism for Dalits

- **Dalit Buddhist Movement** — most successful in **Maharashtra** (large-scale conversions)
- Ambedkar's **"Neo Buddhism"**: strong element of **social and political protest** against Hinduism and the Indian caste system — not just spiritual but a political act of defiance

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Neo-Buddhist Identity:** Ambedkar's conversion movement created a new social category — studied by anthropologists as a form of identity politics and resistance through religious conversion
- **Engaged Buddhism:** Modern Buddhist movements in India combine spiritual practice with social activism (anti-caste, environmental) — blurring religion and politics
- **Soft Power:** India's Buddhist heritage sites (Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Nalanda) are diplomatic tools in relations with East/SE Asian nations — "Buddhist circuit" tourism strategy
- **Dalai Lama & Tibetan Refugees:** Buddhism's living political significance — Dharamsala as centre of exiled government; refugee integration studied anthropologically
- **Mindfulness Movement:** Buddhist meditation practices secularised globally (mindfulness-based stress reduction) — studying how religious concepts get decontextualised and commodified
- **Article 51A(h):** Constitutional duty to develop "scientific temper" — traces back to Buddhist emphasis on reasoned inquiry over blind faith

Essence of Jainism

Three Jewels (Ratnatraya)

Jewel	Sanskrit	Meaning
1st Jewel	Samyak Darshan	"Right Faith" — correct perception of reality
2nd Jewel	Samyak Jnana	"Right Knowledge" — undistorted knowledge
3rd Jewel	Samyak Charitra	"Right Conduct" — ethical behaviour

One cannot exist without the others — all three required for spiritual liberation (moksha)

Five Maha-vratas (Great Vows of Ascetics)

#	Vow	Sanskrit	Meaning
1	Non-violence	Ahimsa	No harm to any living being
2	Truth	Satya	Always speak truth
3	Non-stealing	Achaurya / Asteya	Do not take what is not given
4	Non-possession	Aparigraha	Non-attachment to material things
5	Celibacy	Brahmacharya	Chastity and sexual restraint

Right knowledge, right faith, and right conduct are the three essentials for attaining liberation. The five great vows operationalise these in daily life.

Positive Impacts

1. Social Equality

- Jainism **rejects the caste system** and advocates for equality
- Monastic communities **do not discriminate** — anyone can pursue spiritual path

 **Romila Thapar**

*Such sectarian movements **challenged Brahmanical orthodoxy** and offered **parallel paths of dignity** to those excluded from the Vedic fold*

2. Ethical Values & Ahimsa (Non-Violence)

- Jainism places the **strongest emphasis on non-violence** of any Indian religion
- Influenced Indian society to promote **compassion and respect for ALL living beings**
- Many Jains adhere to **vegetarian lifestyle**, avoiding harm to animals
- Engage in **charitable activities** to support non-violence (animal shelters, hospitals)

 **A. L. Basham**

*Highlighted Jain ascetic ideals of **restraint and compassion** as one of the strongest **moral vocabularies** of ancient India — influencing even Hindu vegetarianism*

3. Language

- Jainism contributed to evolution of **Prakrit language** through its teachings
- Designed for accessibility to **common people** (not elitist Sanskrit)

Romila Thapar

*This widened the **reading public** and **democratised learning** — knowledge was no longer the monopoly of Sanskrit-educated Brahmins*

PART C: IMPACT OF JAINISM ON INDIAN SOCIETY (Unit 3.4)

JAINISM — 7 SPHERES OF IMPACT

1. Social Equality
2. Ahimsa/Ethics
3. Language (Prakrit)
4. Social Welfare
5. Education
6. Art & Architecture
7. Austerity Principles

Context & Emergence

- One of the oldest **sramana** (ascetic) traditions
- Emerged in the **6th century BCE** alongside Buddhism as a movement questioning Vedic orthodoxy
- Emphasis on **ahimsa** (non-violence), **austerity**, and **spiritual discipline**
- Has left a deep and lasting imprint on Indian society far beyond its numerical strength

4. Social Welfare Initiatives

- Construction of **dharamshalas** (pilgrims' rest houses) — located near pilgrimage destinations
- Provided spiritual pilgrims with shelter — practical manifestation of Jain principles of **hospitality and communal welfare**

 **R. C. Majumdar**

*Mercantile patronage made **Jain temples and inns civic hubs** — centres of community life, not just religious spaces*

5. Education & Scholarship

- Jainism has a **long tradition of scholarship** and education
- Many Jain monks contributed to intellectual and educational development
- **Tattvartha Sutra** — instrumental in shaping philosophical discussions and intellectual pursuits in India
- Jain libraries (*bhandaras*) preserved ancient manuscripts for centuries

6. Art & Architecture

Form	Key Examples & Significance
Rock-cut caves	Hindu & Jain rock-cut architecture at Badami, Aihole, Ajanta, Ellora, Elephanta, Aurangabad, Mamallapuram
Temple construction	Gommateshwara Bahubali statue at Shravanabelagola — revered Jain pilgrimage destination; one of tallest monolithic statues in the world
Paintings	Kalpa Sutra — manuscript with biographies of Tirthankaras (particularly Parshvanatha & Mahavira); canvas for intricate Jain painting tradition

CASE STUDY: ELLORA COMPLEX (UNESCO)

Not only a unique artistic creation and technological exploit — with its sanctuaries devoted to **Buddhism, Hinduism & Jainism** — it illustrates the **spirit of tolerance** characteristic of ancient India. Three religions coexisting in one architectural complex.

7. Principles of Austerity

Jainism promoted virtues of:

- Voluntary simplicity
- Fasting (as spiritual discipline)
- Humility
- Selfless service
- Pursuit of knowledge
- Meditation

These values influenced broader Indian culture's emphasis on *tapas* (austerity) and simple living.

Spread of Jainism

- Jainism was **NOT widely embraced** due to:
 - Its **stringent orthodoxy** (extreme demands on followers)
 - **Affinity to Brahmanism** (didn't challenge it as strongly as Buddhism)
 - **Non-missionary spirit** — no active proselytisation
 - Virtual absence of aggression in spreading
- Most converts were from **Vaishya** (merchant) community — natural fit with ahimsa and trade
- Jainism is India's **6th largest religion**

44,51,753

Jains in India (2011 Census) — majority in Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat & Madhya Pradesh. Yet influence on Indian culture is **far greater than these numbers suggest**.

Criticisms & Limitations

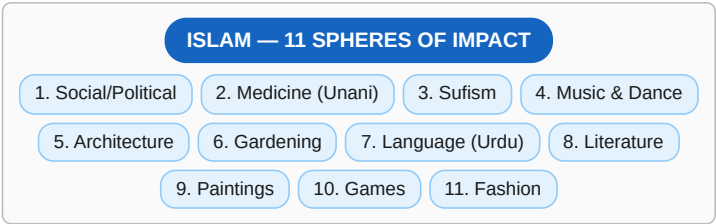
Social Separation & Isolation

 **Romila Thapar:** Jainism's strict commitment to ahimsa and ritual purity often led to **social separation and isolation** of Jain communities. While it promoted compassion, it sometimes weakened **social cohesion** with other groups — Jain communities became insular.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Environmental Ethics:** Jain ahimsa is being reinterpreted as an ecological philosophy — reverence for all life forms aligns with modern environmental anthropology and deep ecology
- **Animal Rights:** Jain pinjrapoles (animal shelters) are among the world's oldest institutional forms of animal welfare — studied as cultural models for animal rights movements
- **Corporate Social Responsibility:** Jain business families (Birla, Bangur, Singhania) practice *aparigraha*-inspired philanthropy — relevant to studying religion-business nexus
- **Food Culture:** Jain dietary restrictions (no root vegetables, no eating after sunset) have influenced India's food industry and restaurant culture — anthropology of food
- **Minority Studies:** Jains sought minority status (granted in 2014) — raises questions about how a wealthy but numerically small community navigates identity politics
- **Sustainable Living:** Jain principles of *aparigraha* and voluntary simplicity resonate with modern minimalism and anti-consumerism movements

PART D: IMPACT OF ISLAM ON INDIAN SOCIETY (Unit 3.4)



Entry into India

- Islam entered India from the **7th century onwards** through **trade, migration**, and later **political expansion**
- Shaped Indian society in multiple dimensions: religion and culture to economy, administration, and everyday social practices
- India is home to **Hinduism, Islam, Buddhism, Jainism, Christianity, and Zoroastrianism** — since all lived together, they influenced each other and Indian society as a whole

1. Social & Political Life

- Many people from **deprived castes** were attracted to Islam — promised equality
- Impact on the constitution observable through the **Hindu Marriage Act and Succession Act**
- Islam affected the position of Indian women — in some practices, birth of a girl considered inauspicious (this spread to some Hindu communities too)

 **Harbans Mukhia**
*Mohammed preached the **doctrine of one God** in polytheistic Arabia — "the concept of one god meant the concept of **social equality**" — monotheism carried an inherently egalitarian message*

 **Dr. Tara Chand (eminent historian-philosopher)**
*Emphasised the message of **sulhe-kul** ("peace for all and complete peace") of the Muslim **Sufi Silsilah** (mystic orders) — a message of universal harmony that transcended religious boundaries*

2. Medicine

- Muslims introduced the **Unani system of medicine** in India
- The term **Yunani** means "Greek" — the Perso-Arabic system was based on teachings of Greek physicians **Hippocrates and Galen**
- Unani medicine still practised widely in India; recognised by AYUSH Ministry

3. Sufism

- Sufism = mystical Islamic belief and practice in which Muslims seek truth of divine love and knowledge through **direct personal experience of God**
- Sufi saints played crucial role in cultural synthesis between Hindu and Muslim communities

Richard Eaton
*Sufi saints often **integrated local practices**, producing a **syncretic culture** — they didn't impose; they absorbed and blended*

CASE STUDY: NIZAMUDDIN AULIYA (1238-1325 CE), DELHI
Nizamuddin Dargah — mausoleum of Sufi saint Khwaja Nizamuddin Auliya. Situated in Nizamuddin West, Delhi. Visited by **thousands every week** (both Hindu and Muslim devotees). Known for evening **qawwali** devotional music sessions. Exemplifies Hindu-Muslim syncretic worship.

4. Music & Dance

 **B. S. Upadhyaya (eminent Indologist)**
*In his well-known work **Feeders of Indian Culture** (1973) — described in detail the contribution of Islam and Muslims in reconstruction of Indian society through the field of **music***

Contribution	Details
Instruments	Sitar and Tabla — brought to India by Muslims; now synonymous with Indian classical music
Devotional Music	Qawwali — mystical Sufi music; accepted and loved by Hindus too
Dance	Kathak (The Indo-Persian Dance Style) — unique in having both Hindu and Muslim gharanas . Performances include Urdu Ghazals and Mughal-era instruments. Dance was jointly performed by Hindus and Muslims.
Great Contributor	Amir Khusro — poet, musician, scholar; pioneer of Indo-Islamic cultural fusion

5. Architecture

- Muslims introduced **domes, minarets, turrets, and arches** — greatly accepted by Indians
- Examples: **Taj Mahal, Buland Darwaza, Alai Darwaza**

 **Rosharduddin Khan**
***Khanqahs** (monasteries) "provided refuge to the oppressed and wretched, the miserable, the down-trodden and the disinherited, **irrespective of caste and creed**" — social welfare institutions open to all*

6. Gardening

- **Charbagh style** — Persian and Indo-Persian quadrilateral garden layout
- Based on the **four gardens of Paradise** mentioned in the Quran
- The quadrilateral garden is divided by **walkways or flowing water** into four smaller parts
- Example: Gardens of Taj Mahal, Humayun's Tomb, Shalimar Bagh

7. Language

- The synthesis of Islam and Hinduism gave birth to a new language: **Urdu**
- Became the common language of both communities — lingua franca of much of North India
- Great contributor:  **Mirza Ghalib** — greatest Urdu poet

8. Literary Contribution

- Islam played a **pivotal role in shaping historiography** — Indians didn't have a strong tradition of historical writing before Islamic scholars
- Notable works: **Babarnama, Akbarnama, Ain-i-Akbari** — detailed historical records of Mughal era

Frances Pritchett
*Persian literary traditions **enriched Indian languages** — Urdu poetry, Persian prose styles, the ghazal form all became integral to Indian literature*

9. Paintings

- **Mughal painting** = particular style of South Asian painting
- Confined to **miniatures** — either as book illustrations or single works kept in albums called **muraqqa**
- Emerged from **Persian miniature painting** (itself partly of Chinese origin)
- Developed in the court of the Mughal Empire (16th–18th centuries)
- **Reign of Jahangir** saw painting at its **zenith** — naturalistic portraiture, detailed botanical studies

10. Games & Entertainment

- Many Indian sports and entertainments were enriched: hunting, hawking, kite-flying, and **chess (Shatranj)** became popular

CASE STUDY: SHATRANJ (CHESS)

Shatranj = old form of chess as played in the Sasanian Empire. Its origins are in the **Indian game of chaturanga**. Modern chess gradually developed from this — introduced to Europe by contacts in Muslim **Al-Andalus** (modern Spain) and in **Sicily in the 10th century**. A perfect example of Indo-Islamic-European cultural transmission.

11. Fashion & Jewellery

- **Mughal dress patterns** were adopted by Hindu rulers — exemplifying cross-cultural impact of Islamic aesthetics on Indian attire
- The **nose ring (Nath)** evolved into a symbol of Hindu marriage, drawing inspiration from Muslim traditions
- Sherwanis, salwar-kameez, dupatta — all Islamic fashion influences that became pan-Indian

Negative Impacts of Islam

1. Purdah & Women's Subordination

Romila Thapar: Certain rigid practices like **purdah** (veiling/seclusion of women) contributed to the **subordination of women** in Indian society — spread beyond Muslim communities to Hindu upper castes

2. Conversion & Social Tensions

K. S. Lal: Argued that mass conversions sometimes caused **social tensions between communities** — creating faultlines that persist today

3. Religious Orthodoxy

Strict enforcement of orthodoxy in certain regimes **narrowed religious tolerance** at times — in contrast to the syncretic Sufi stream. Not all Islamic rulers followed the tolerant Sufi path.

SUMMARY: ISLAM'S LEGACY

The influence of Islam on Indian society was **profound and diverse**. It reshaped art, architecture, language, music, cuisine, education, and social norms, while also introducing new forms of spirituality through Sufism. The interaction of Islamic and indigenous traditions produced a **rich cultural synthesis** that continues to shape Indian identity today.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Syncretism Studies**: Sufi shrines (dargahs) where Hindus and Muslims worship together are key sites for studying religious syncretism — challenged by growing communal polarisation
- **Composite Culture (Ganga-Jamuni Tehzeeb)**: The Hindi-Urdu continuum, shared festivals (Muharram processions with Hindu participation), and composite architecture are living evidence of cultural synthesis
- **Identity & Communalism**: The tension between syncretic and separatist interpretations of Islam in India is central to understanding communalism — anthropologists study how shared spaces become contested
- **Artisan Communities**: Muslim artisan communities (weavers of Varanasi, Zardozi workers, carpet makers) preserve craft traditions endangered by globalisation — studied under economic anthropology
- **Food Anthropology**: Mughlai cuisine, biryani variants, kebab traditions — food as a site of cultural synthesis and identity
- **Legal Pluralism**: Personal law debates (Triple Talaq abolition 2019, Uniform Civil Code), Shah Bano case — how religious law coexists/conflicts with secular law

PART E: IMPACT OF CHRISTIANITY ON INDIAN SOCIETY (Unit 3.4)

CHRISTIANITY — 8 SPHERES OF IMPACT

1. Health
2. Education
3. Social Reform
4. Egalitarianism
5. Cultural
6. Heritage Rediscovery
7. Westernisation
8. Administration

Entry into India

- Christianity entered India as early as **52 AD** with the arrival of **St. Thomas** on the **Malabar Coast**
- Real spread came with **European missionaries from the 16th century onwards**
- Shaped education, healthcare, social reforms, architecture, and culture
- Influence far greater than its numerical strength in India

Victor D'Souza

*"In India, Christianity has been one of the important factors of **modernization and economic development** through the social values it has legitimized" — it introduced new ways of organising society*

Essence of Christianity

- **Universal brotherhood** — all humans are children of one God
- **Egalitarian outlook** — no inherent hierarchy between humans
- **Service of the under-privileged** — charity and care for the poor/sick

Positive Impacts

1. Health Initiatives

- Christianity established hospitals — **pioneered social welfare**, addressing gaps in government reach
- Notable in **North-East India**: Christian missions provided healthcare where the state was absent
- CMC Vellore** (Christian Medical College) — legacy of missionary health service; one of India's premier medical institutions today

William Sweet

Christian missions *institutionalised hospitals and clinics*, making modern medicine accessible to populations that had no other access to allopathic healthcare

2. Educational Impact

- Language Introduction**: English as a medium of instruction (influenced by Christian values) — became a **unifying language** among Western-educated individuals
- Christianity established **schools where government reach was limited** — especially in remote tribal and hilly areas

92%

literacy rate in **Mizoram** — attributed directly to Christian missions establishing schools in every village

Teotonio R. de Souza

Missionaries introduced *modern education and literacy*, shaping India's early Western-educated elite — the very elite that would later lead the independence movement

Arun Shourie (critical but useful to cite)

Noted that missionary education had both *reformist and cultural assimilationist aims* — education came with evangelisation; the two were intertwined

3. Social Reforms & Opposition to Caste System

- Christian teachings influenced educated individuals to **challenge the Hindu caste system**
- This opposition led to significant socio-religious reforms
- Advocacy against caste discrimination by Christian leaders in various regions

John C. B. Webster

Emphasized missionary efforts in challenging *untouchability* and promoting **social justice** — missionaries often worked with the most marginalised communities

4. Advocacy for Egalitarian Society

- Christianity's emphasis on **equality** and opposition to social stratification played a crucial role in shaping India's reform movements
- Influenced Indian reformers: Ram Mohan Roy, Keshub Chandra Sen were inspired by Christian egalitarian ideas while remaining within Hindu fold

5. Cultural Contributions

Domain	Examples & Impact
Architecture	Basilica of Bom Jesus in Goa — iconic Christian architectural influence; Gothic, Baroque styles introduced
Music	Orchestra, guitar, piano introduced into Indian society — Western musical instruments became mainstream
Clothing	Western formals became mainstream — "Just see what formals boys wear to UPSC interview" (from class notes!)

6. Heritage Rediscovery

British efforts (often influenced by Christian perspectives) led to **rediscovery of Indian heritage sites**:

Person	Year	Discovery
Henry Taylor	1818	Rediscovered Sanchi Stupa
John Smith	1819	Stumbled upon Ajanta Caves
James Prinsep	1837	Deciphered Brahmi script — unlocked entire ancient Indian history

7. Westernisation & Economic Development

- Christianity served as an **early channel for Westernisation** — introducing Western culture and practices

B. B. Misra

Christianity acted as a *channel of Western political ideas* — paving the way for **liberalism and democratic institutions** in India. Ideas of individual rights, equality before law came through this route.

8. Administrative System Adoption

- Influenced the adoption of administrative systems including the **three branches: Legislature, Executive, and Judiciary** (from European models)
- Role in the **unification of India's administrative systems** under British colonial rule
- Modern bureaucratic organisation, rule of law, codified laws — all introduced through the Christian-influenced colonial apparatus

Negative Impacts of Christianity

1. Conversion Conflicts

Missionary conversion efforts sometimes led to **communal tensions and conflicts**.
Example: Kandhamal violence (2008) in Odisha — anti-Christian riots triggered by conversion disputes.
Susan Bayly: Disputes over conversion often created **localised social strife** — communities torn apart by conversion and reconversion movements.

2. Cultural Assimilation & Loss

Teotonio R. de Souza: Aggressive cultural assimilation sometimes **eroded indigenous practices** — European customs replaced traditional Indian ways of life. Tribal converts often lost their traditional cultural identity.

Summary

2.3%

- of Indian population — yet Christianity's influence on education, healthcare, social reforms, art & politics has been **profoundly disproportionate** to its numbers
- From **Mother Teresa's** humanitarian work to **Mizoram's literacy success**
 - Christianity has left a legacy of social change, cultural enrichment & spiritual inspiration that continues to shape Indian society today

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Conversion Debate:** Anti-conversion laws in 12+ states (Freedom of Religion Acts) — anthropologists study how "choice" and "inducement" are constructed; agency of converts vs structural pressures
- **North-East Identity:** Christianity is majority religion in Nagaland, Mizoram, Meghalaya — shaped tribal identity, modernisation, and political aspirations; Naga nationalism partly rooted in Christian identity
- **Dalit Christianity:** Dalit converts face caste discrimination WITHIN the Church (separate cemeteries, pews) — challenges the narrative that conversion eliminates caste
- **Liberation Theology:** Christian activists in India use theology to justify social justice work — land rights, anti-mining movements in Jharkhand/Chhattisgarh
- **Medical Anthropology:** CMC Vellore, St. John's Bangalore — missionary hospitals pioneered community health approaches now studied as models of healthcare delivery in resource-poor settings
- **Language & Script:** Missionaries created scripts for many tribal languages (Ol Chiki for Santali by Raghunath Murmu was inspired by missionary script-creation tradition) — preserving linguistic diversity

MASTER COMPARATIVE TABLE: ALL FOUR RELIGIONS

Dimension	Buddhism	Jainism	Islam
Entry/Origin	6th c. BCE India	6th c. BCE India	7th c. CE (trade/migration)
Core Message	Eightfold Path; equality; achieved status	Ratnatraya + Ahimsa; austerity	One God = equality; Sulhe-kul (Sufi peace)
Social Impact	Rejected varna; Sangha open to all	Rejected caste; non-discrimination in monastic life	Attracted deprived castes; purdah as negative
Education	Nalanda, Taxila, Vikramshila (world's first universities)	Tattvartha Sutra; bhandaras (libraries)	Historiography: Babarnama, Ain-i-Akbari
Art/Architecture	Gandhara/Mathura; stupas; Ajanta paintings	Ellora; Gommateshwara; Kalpa Sutra paintings	Domes/arches; Taj Mahal; Mughal miniatures
Language	Pali — democratised learning	Prakrit — democratised learning	Urdu — synthesis of Hindu-Muslim
Key Negative	Military decline; monastic withdrawal	Social isolation of Jain communities	Purdah; conversion tensions; orthodoxy
Contemporary	Neo-Buddhism; soft power diplomacy	Environmental ethics; CSR; food culture	Syncretism vs communalism; craft traditions

QUICK REVISION CHEAT SHEET

L-46: Future of Caste | Impact of Religions on Indian Society

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Key Data	Contemporary Hook
Future of Caste	Persistence + transformation; endogamy; political reinforcement; identity-based (not ritual); caste associations; Dalit Capitalism	Srinivas (Sanskritisation); Ambedkar (Annihilation); Beteille (caste vs class); Kolenda (1000 yrs); Jaffrelot (empowerment); Narmadeshwar Prasad (survey 1957); Chandra Bhan Prasad	DICCI; Yadav/Brahmin Assocs; EWS 2019; Bihar Survey 2023; Mandal 1992; NAMASTE 2022	5% inter-caste (IHDS-2); 27% untouchability; 39.1% education remedy; UP: 41,000/46,000 leather workers	Digital caste; California SB 403; sub-categorisation of OBCs; intersectionality
Buddhism	Egalitarianism; achieved status; women nuns; civic ethics; Pali democratisation; Eightfold Path; trade monasteries; ethical kingship; military decline; Neo-Buddhism	R.S. Sharma ; Uma Chakravarti (Therigatha); Radhakrishnan (civic ethics); Gombrich (reasoned inquiry); Basham (Gandhara/Mathura); Upinder Singh (trade); Kulke (welfare); Thapar (dhamma); Majumdar (Taxila)	Nalanda; Sanchi; Ajanta; Tipitaka; Jataka; Therigatha; Maha Bodhi Society 1891; Ambedkar-Maharashtra	9 missionaries (Mahavamsa); Sanghamitra + Mahindra → Sri Lanka	Buddhist Circuit tourism; Dalai Lama; mindfulness movement; Art 51A(h)
Jainism	Ratnatraya (3 jewels); 5 Mahavratas; ahimsa strongest; Prakrit; dharamshalas; austerity; non-missionary; 6th largest religion; Vaishya base	Romila Thapar (challenged orthodoxy + social isolation); Basham (moral vocabulary); R.C. Majumdar (civic hubs)	Ellora complex; Gommateshwara Shravanabelagola; Kalpa Sutra; Tattvartha Sutra; Parshvanatha/Mahavira	44,51,753 Jains (2011); MH/Raj/Guj/MP majority	Environmental ethics; animal rights; minority status 2014; food industry influence
Islam	One God = equality; Sufism = syncretism; Unani medicine; Urdu birth; domes/arches; Charbagh; Kathak; miniature painting; purdah negative; khanqahs	Harbans Mukhia (one God); Tara Chand (sulhe-kul); Eaton (syncretic Sufis); Upadhyaya (music 1973); Rosherduddin Khan (khanqahs); Pritchett (Persian lit); K.S. Lal (tensions); Thapar (purdah)	Nizamuddin Auliya; Taj Mahal; Sitar/Tabla; Qawwali; Amir Khusro; Mirza Ghalib; Shatranj → Chess; Nath (nose ring)	Jahangir = painting zenith; Chess via Al-Andalus 10th c.	Ganga-Jamuni Tehzeeb; Triple Talaq 2019; UCC debate; artisan communities; dargah syncretism
Christianity	52 AD St. Thomas; universal brotherhood; health pioneer; English medium; heritage rediscovery (Brahmi/Ajanta/Sanchi); Westernisation channel; 3 branches; conversion conflicts	Victor D'Souza (modernisation); Sweet (hospitals); Teotonio de Souza (education + cultural loss); Shourie (assimilationist); Webster (anti-untouchability); B.B. Misra (political ideas); Susan Bayly (strife)	CMC Vellore; Basilica Bom Jesus; Mizoram 92%; Mother Teresa; guitar/piano; Kandhamal 2008	2.3% population; 52 AD entry; Sanchi 1818; Ajanta 1819; Brahmi 1837	Anti-conversion laws (12+ states); NE identity; Dalit Christianity; liberation theology

Master Scholar Quick-Reference

Scholar	Key One-Liner (quotable in exam)	Topic
M. N. Srinivas	Caste adapts via Sanskritisation & Westernisation — doesn't disappear	Caste
Andre Beteille	Caste vs class tension defines India's social structure	Caste
Pauline Kolenda	1000-year system won't vanish in decades	Caste
Christophe Jaffrelot	Caste politics empowered marginalised groups — new bargaining power	Caste
Narmadeshwar Prasad	Survey 1957: education (39.1%) & inter-caste marriage (35.3%) = top remedies	Caste
R. S. Sharma	Buddhism: achieved > ascribed status; weakened Vedic ritual economy	Buddhism
Uma Chakravarti	Therigatha = Buddhist nuns' intellectual & spiritual autonomy	Buddhism
S. Radhakrishnan	Buddhist principles = civic ethics beyond ritual sanction	Buddhism
Richard Gombrich	Pali canon: reasoned inquiry as default mode of learning	Buddhism
A. L. Basham	Gandhara/Mathura art schools; Jain moral vocabulary of ancient India	Buddhism + Jainism
Romila Thapar	Ashoka's dhamma = ethical kingship; Jainism: challenged orthodoxy but caused isolation; Purdah → women's subordination	All 4
Harbans Mukhia	One God = social equality (Islam's core social message)	Islam
Dr. Tara Chand	Sufi message of sulhe-kul = peace for all	Islam
Richard Eaton	Sufis integrated local practices → syncretic culture	Islam
B. S. Upadhyaya	<i>Feeders of Indian Culture</i> (1973) — Islam's music contribution	Islam
Victor D'Souza	Christianity = modernisation + economic development factor	Christianity
B. B. Misra	Christianity channelled Western political ideas (liberalism)	Christianity
Susan Bayly	Conversion disputes → localised social strife	Christianity

MNEMONICS FOR QUICK RECALL

4 Religions' Core Impact (BEJC): Buddhism = Equality + Ethics | Jainism = Ahimsa + Austerity | Islam = Syncretism + Aesthetics | Christianity = Modernisation + Education

Caste Persistence (EPE): Endogamy (5%) + Politics (Mandal/vote banks) + Entrenched attitudes (27% untouchability)

Buddhism's 9 Impacts (SEE-ILEAP): Social equality, Ethics, Education, Intellectual freedom, Literature, Economic life, Art, Political life + Women

Islam's Contributions (SMULAG-PGF): Sufism, Medicine, Urdu, Literature, Architecture, Games, Paintings, Gardening, Fashion + Music/Dance

Jain 5 Vows (ASAB²): Ahimsa, Satya, Asteya, Brahmacharya, aParigraha